

CLAIMS PROCEDURE & EVIDENCE GUIDE

HomeShield Insurance Group | Claims Department | 2025 Edition

This guide provides step-by-step claims procedures for each major peril type, the evidence required, and timelines you can expect throughout the process.

ESCAPE OF WATER / BURST PIPE

Immediate Actions

- Turn off the water supply at the stopcock immediately
- Turn off the central heating and immersion heater
- Move furniture, rugs, and electrical items away from the affected area
- Take photographs of all water damage before any drying or cleaning begins
- Call an emergency plumber if the leak cannot be stopped with the stopcock
- Contact HomeShield within 24 hours on 0800 555 0800

Evidence Required

- Photographs of all affected areas and damaged items (minimum 6 photos)
- Plumber's report identifying the source of the leak
- Receipts or estimates for emergency plumbing work
- Drying/damp survey report (HomeShield will instruct a specialist)
- Receipts for any damaged contents items (or bank statements as proof of purchase)
- Two independent repair quotes for reinstatement works over £2,500

Timeline

Claim decision: 15 working days from receipt of all documents. Trace and access: approved within 5 working days.

Important Notes

Do not dry out affected areas with fans before HomeShield's moisture survey — this may affect the assessment of damage extent.

STORM DAMAGE

Immediate Actions

- Ensure the property is safe before entering — check for structural instability
- Contact emergency services if the property is unsafe
- Carry out emergency temporary repairs only (board up broken windows, tarpaulin on roof) — keep all receipts
- Do NOT remove debris or fallen trees until photographed and assessed
- Contact HomeShield within 24 hours

Evidence Required

- Photographs of all external and internal storm damage
- Photographs of fallen trees, damaged roofing materials, etc.
- Weather data report (HomeShield will obtain; you may also submit Met Office records)
- Receipts for emergency temporary repairs
- Two independent repair quotes for reinstatement
- Receipts/valuations for any damaged contents

Timeline

Emergency board-up/tarpaulin: HomeShield authorises within 4 hours. Full claim decision: 15 working days.

Important Notes

Storm definition: winds exceeding 55 mph (Beaufort Scale Force 10). HomeShield will verify windspeed data for your postcode.

FIRE DAMAGE

Immediate Actions

- Evacuate the property and call 999 immediately
- Do NOT re-enter until fire service declares it safe
- Obtain fire brigade report or incident number
- Contact HomeShield immediately — our emergency team will arrange alternative accommodation if needed
- Do NOT begin any clean-up or salvage without HomeShield's agreement

Evidence Required

- Fire brigade incident report / incident reference number
- Photographs of all fire, smoke, and water damage from firefighting
- Inventory of damaged or destroyed contents with original receipts where possible
- Arson investigation report (if applicable)
- Two independent structural engineer reports (for major fires)
- Receipts for emergency hotel/accommodation costs

Timeline

Alternative accommodation: authorised within 24 hours. Total loss assessment: 30 working days. Major rebuild: ongoing with regular updates.

Important Notes

HomeShield will appoint a specialist fire damage restoration company. Do not sign any contracts with third-party restorers without prior written approval.

THEFT AND BURGLARY

Immediate Actions

- Do NOT touch anything in the property — it is a crime scene
- Call the police immediately — dial 999 if the intruder may still be on the premises
- Obtain a police crime reference number — this is mandatory for all theft claims
- Photograph all points of entry and any damage caused
- Make a list of all stolen or damaged items as soon as possible
- Contact HomeShield within 24 hours

Evidence Required

- Police crime reference number (mandatory — claim will not be processed without this)
- Photographs of all forced entry points and damage
- Inventory of stolen items with descriptions, serial numbers if known
- Proof of ownership: receipts, bank statements, warranty cards, photographs
- For jewellery/watches: original purchase receipts or professional valuations (within 5 years)
- CCTV footage (if available)

Timeline

Initial response: 5 working days. Claim decision: 15 working days from receipt of all documents.

Important Notes

Theft from outbuildings requires evidence that the outbuilding was locked at the time. Theft without forced entry (e.g., unlocked door or window) may not be covered.

FLOOD DAMAGE

Immediate Actions

- Do NOT enter flood-damaged property until utilities (electricity, gas) are confirmed safe
- Contact your local council flood response team
- Photograph all external flood levels and internal damage before any drying
- Remove furniture to prevent further damage only after photographing in situ
- Contact HomeShield within 24 hours — we will arrange a loss adjuster urgently

Evidence Required

- Photographs and video of external flood levels (include door frame or ruler for scale)
- Photographs of all internal damage before any drying or clean-up
- Flood alert records from the Environment Agency for the incident date
- List of all damaged contents with purchase receipts or bank statements
- Damp/moisture survey report (HomeShield will instruct)
- Receipts for emergency hotel/alternative accommodation
- Two independent structural engineer quotes for reinstatement

Timeline

Alternative accommodation: authorised within 24 hours. Drying and initial reinstatement: 6–12 weeks. Major flood reinstatement: 3–12 months.

Important Notes

Flood damage can take 6–12 months to fully dry out. HomeShield will provide specialist drying equipment and regular moisture monitoring throughout the reinstatement period.

SUBSIDENCE

Immediate Actions

- Photograph ALL cracks with a ruler for scale — note the date photographs were taken
- Record whether cracks are getting worse (crack monitors can be purchased from DIY stores)
- Do NOT carry out any repair work without HomeShield's written approval
- Inform HomeShield in writing within 30 days of first noticing the cracking
- Do not obscure cracks with filler or paint before HomeShield's inspection

Evidence Required

- Photographs of all cracks with a ruler for scale (mandatory)
- Written description of when cracks were first noticed and how they have changed
- Any independent structural survey report you have obtained
- Records of any nearby tree removal, excavation, or building work that may have affected the ground
- Previous subsidence claims or NHBC warranty information (if applicable)
- Records of any previous underpinning or foundation work

Timeline

HomeShield appoints structural surveyor: within 10 working days. Survey report: 15–20 working days. Underpinning approval (if required): 30–60 working days.

Important Notes

Subsidence investigations take time. HomeShield monitors crack movement for a minimum of 12 months before authorising underpinning — this is standard industry practice.

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